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ORIGINAL ARTICLE

Getting what you pay for: Resource allocations and legislative success

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Abstract

Members of Congress run for office with a variety of goals they hope to achieve if elected. How members go about achieving these goals is constrained by numerous institutional factors. Yet there exist two areas in which members are afforded broad discretion: the allocation of their time and budget. In this paper, I assess the personal qualities and institutional circumstances that motivate members' budgetary decisions, and take an important step further to evaluate the consequences of such choices. I find that members who spend a greater proportion of their budget are more effective lawmakers than those who do not spend their full budgets. Further, I demonstrate that members who invest more in legislative staff have the highest rates of legislative productivity. Members make strategic choices in how they divide their budget. This paper demonstrates that investing in skilled staff is a wise strategy for members desiring legislative success.

Article I of the U.S. Constitution establishes a handful of qualifications for members of Congress and details the powers of the United States Congress. It does not, however, define the job nor the responsibilities of a member of Congress. This lack of a job description affords members great discretion in determining what they want to do as an elected official, what kind of elected official they want to be, and how they want to achieve these ends.

As congressional candidates deliver their stump speech on the campaign trail, many profess a desire to "protect democracy," "save America," or "fix [D.C.'s] problems."[1] These aspirations are repeated frequently throughout campaigns, often with little specificity about how a candidate might go about trying to accomplish said goals if elected. Naturally, there are institutional factors which constrain incoming members' behavior to a significant degree. They are stuck with whatever offices no one else wanted; they can make requests for committee assignments, but often get placed where there are open seats; and they are at the bottom of the seniority rankings, affecting their order of recognition and the expertise they are perceived to hold. Yet despite the myriad constraints a member might face from the institution, there remain two critical resources over which members have near total control: their time and the allocation of their congressionally funded budget. How a member chooses to spend these resources, then, can be interpreted as a direct reflection of her priorities and evidence of how she seeks to achieve her representational goals.

Preeminent scholars have taken steps to uncover what might motivate these decisions (see e.g., Fenno, 1978; Hall, 1998), but what I seek to uncover in this paper is the relationship between the division of a member's budget and her legislative success, and how this division changes over time and circumstances. More specifically, I evaluate the extent to which a members' investment in their legislative operation changes depending on institutional factors, and whether an increased investment is associated with higher rates of legislative productivity. Members of Congress make strategic choices in how they choose to divide their budget. This work analyzes the consequences of these choices.

Richard Fenno famously argued in his study of members' "homestyle" that members of Congress make conscious decisions about their allocation of resources to

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their district, yet I suggest that observing how members allocate their resources, broadly, tells us more about their representational priorities than simply their homestyle (Fenno, 1978). Where members choose to spend their time and how they go about dividing their scarce financial resources gives us a window into where their priorities lie.

This allocation of resources—namely time and staff—is precisely the subject of Richard Fenno's famed book, *Home Style: House Members in their Districts* (Fenno, 1978). Fenno argues that by studying how members allocate their resources, one can learn a great deal about what kind of member they are and what kind of home style they employ. Fenno observes this allocation of resources by tracking the number of trips members of Congress take back to their districts and measuring what he calls the "strength" of a member's district staff, or the amount of staff located in a member's district. These choices about how to divide resources, Fenno argues, are indicative of what type of representational style a member will adopt and what type of legislator they will be.

Expanding on Fenno's groundbreaking qualitative study of members in their districts, I take an important step further and assess the consequences of such decisions. As Fenno established—and recent work has confirmed (Crosson et al., 2021)—members of Congress allocate resources differently, which results in varying representational styles. Some members might spend a greater portion of her budget on travel back home to her district, prioritizing casework and connecting with constituents, while others pursue a robust policy agenda, securing benefits for her district via legislative success. Members can certainly pursue a mixture of these two strategies, or a variety of others, yet all require resources. Trips to one's district cost time and money. Navigating the legislative process similarly consumes a member's time, but also requires financial resources in the form of a competent staff.

While a number of scholars have endeavored to quantify and classify member's representational style (e.g., Bernhard & Sulkin, 2018), several questions remain uncovered. What I seek to address, in particular, are the consequences of members' representational choices—namely, the effect a member's resource allocation has on her legislative capacity, how a member's budgetary strategy changes over time, and how it adjusts due to changes in the budgetary system.

To address these questions, it is necessary to first discuss the process by which members receive their congressionally appropriated resources, or budgets. I then detail the process by which these budgets are allocated and how they have changed over the past several decades. Utilizing publicly disclosed expenditures to isolate the precise allocation of financial resources afforded to each member of Congress, I then analyze the effects of such allocations. I demonstrate that not all members spend their resources equally, and that these divergent spending habits have demonstrable consequences for legislative productivity. Capitalizing on changes made in the 117th Congress in which members received larger budgets than ever before, I demonstrate that those who failed to spend this increase in resources and those who invested funds in non-legislative activities saw no change in legislative performance. Only those members who allocated funds toward legislative staff saw an increase in their effectiveness as lawmakers. By assessing the finite division of each member's budget, we can learn a great deal about the effect of members' financial decisions on their legislative capacity and success as a lawmaker.

1 | MEMBERS OF CONGRESS AND REPRESENTATIONAL STYLE

Beginning with Fenno's preeminent scholarship on members of Congress' representational style, especially what he calls their "homestyle," scholars have taken keen interest in assessing the strategic choices members make about how they allocate their time and resources (Fenno, 1978). From determining how members of Congress convey partisan activities to their constituents (Meinke, 2009), to whether they emphasize moderate or partisan policies and congressional victories (Grimmer, 2013), to how members explain their congressional activity to their constituents (Grose et al., 2015), the types of decisions members make, and how they portray themselves as legislators (Fenno, 1977) are well-studied.

Furthermore, the electoral consequences of such decisions are well-documented. Scholars have taken great steps to build our understanding of the primacy with which members view their electoral goal (Mayhew, 1974), what personal (e.g., female versus male legislators), or district factors (e.g., economically (dis)advantaged districts) might motivate different types of members to adopt a certain style or message over another (Bernhard & Sulkin, 2018; Harden, 2015; Lazarus & Steigerwalt, 2018), and how the public responds to these carefully crafted messages (Broockman & Butler, 2015; Case & Ommundsen, 2024; Grose et al., 2015; Westwood, 2022). What remains understudied, however, are the legislative consequences of members' representational choices.

When considering where members of Congress choose to allocate their resources, it is clear that the vast majority choose to invest in their staff above all else. In the past 10 years, members of Congress, on average, allocate over 70% of their budget toward the compensation of their staff (Brudnick, 2020). While members can choose to set a variety of goals for their

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tenure as a member of Congress, they must rely on staff to help them achieve these goals. Congressional staff are so indispensable to members that they have long been called the "invisible force" behind members of Congress (Fox & Hammond, 1977). Others have been more blunt in their assessment of staff's role calling congressional aides "unelected lawmakers" (Malbin, 1980). However one chooses to define this class of political aides, few dispute their importance.

Political scientists have taken great steps to understand the role that congressional staff play in the lawmaking process—addressing foundational questions of who these staff are (Fox & Hammond, 1977; Kammerer, 1951; Patterson, 1970; Salisbury & Shepsle, 1981a), what experience and qualifications they have (Cain & Drutman, 2014; Fong et al., 2025; Leal & Hess, 2004; Ommundsen, 2023; Romzek & Utter, 1997), and what responsibilities they hold (Curry, 2015; DeGregorio, 1994; Kofmehl, 1962)—to more nuanced assessments of a staffer's responsiveness to her boss' positions (DeGregorio, 1988), responsiveness to constituents' positions (Hertel-Fernandez et al., 2019), the accountability of congressional staff (Romzek, 2000), and the strength and effect of staff networks (Burgat & Hunt, 2020; McCrain, 2018; Montgomery & Nyhan, 2017; Rich, 1977). While these works represent important steps toward a deeper understanding of who congressional staff are and the role they serve, I suggest that a crucial component remains understudied. I seek to add to this growing literature an understanding of legislative consequences members face as a function of how much they invest in their staff. Existing literature makes it clear that members need staff to accomplish their goals, yet the consequences of just how much of an investment members make in their staff remains unclear.

In their study of the role that congressional staff play in legislative capacity, Crosson et al. (2021) conclude that it is not the quantity of staff a member employs that determines the member's legislative capacity, but rather the quality of their staff. These findings are consistent with work conducted by Fong et al. (2025), in which the authors argue that the expertise congressional staff hold is uniquely valuable to members on Capitol Hill (or, in the words of the authors, "firm specific"). Members who care about their legislative productivity and success should, therefore, see the value in investing resources in high-quality congressional staff.

While personnel compensation makes up the majority of a member's annual expenses, there still exists quite a bit of variation in how much members spend on their staff—and on which types of staff—versus other financial obligations. The discretion with which members are afforded when it comes to allocating their budgets has substantial consequences for the legislative success of members and tells a great deal about their representational priorities.

2 | MEMBERS' BUDGETARY DISCRETION

At the beginning of each year in office, members are given an annual budget of just under $2,000,000 with which they fund all official expenses. In 2024, these budgets ranged from $1,849,149 (Rep. Veronica Escobar, D-Texas) to $2,088,499 (Rep. Jerrold Nadler, D-N.Y.), with a mean of $1,928,051.40 and standard deviation of $35,130.72.[2] It is from this account that members pay for their travel between their districts and Washington, expense official mail sent to constituents, purchase office supplies and technology equipment, and compensate employees.

Each member receives a slightly different budget, or members' representational allowance (MRA), as it is a function of the distance from a member's district to Washington and the number of residential mailing addresses in a member's district. The formula to calculate each member's budget is set by the Committee on House Administration and is comprised of three general accounts: personnel compensation, official expenses, and franked mail. In 2024, each member was allocated $1,434,751 for personnel compensation.[3] The "official expenses" category includes a base budget of $134,412, which all members receive, to fund general office expenditures, in addition to a stipend meant to cover 45 round trips from Washington to a member's district and a stipend to rent 2,500 square feet of office space in a member's district.[4] And the size of the final component of a member's budget, intended to be used for official, or "franked," mail, is determined by the number of residential mailing addresses in a member's district. Despite the fact that members' representational allowances are based on this five-part calculation (personnel, office expenses, travel, rent, and franked mail), members do not need to abide by these subcategories and are, rather, given one pot of money from which they fund all congressional expenses.

Prior to the 104th Congress (1995–1996), members of Congress received a distinct allowance for hiring staff, paying general office expenses, and funding official mailing campaigns.[5] If a member chose to spend less than her allocated budget on franked mail, however, she was unable to repurpose those funds for a trip back home to her district. This was true for each budgetary category. The move toward one consolidated account in the 104th Congress was seen as a victory for increased flexibility and greater member autonomy (Brudnick, 2020). Members now have complete discretion as to how they want to allocate their resources across each of the spending categories. The types of items and amount of staff a member can use their MRA to cover remain highly regulated by House rules, yet how members choose to divide this account to cover each category is entirely discretionary.[6] This autonomy allows members the freedom to

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allocate their budget as they see fit. This flexibility is not without its consequences, however, as this consolidated account allows members to operate in what Goodman & Parker, 2010 call a "zero-sum game." In other words, "each dollar spent on franked mail meant one less dollar for hiring staffers or traveling back to their districts" (Goodman & Parker, 2010, p. 255). This zero-sum game gives each member the autonomy to allocate her resources in whatever manner she deems useful for achieving her representational goals. Whether that is spending more of her budget on traveling back to her district or advertising via franked mail, or investing in her legislative capacity through competitive staff salaries, members have the flexibility to make these choices.

Only a handful of scholars have endeavored to understand how members of Congress spend their budgets. Lazarus and Steigerwalt (2018) consider whether women might make different choices regarding resource allocation as a result of their perception of electoral vulnerability. They find that congresswomen do align both their roll-call behavior and committee work more closely with constituent preferences than their male counterparts, but they find mixed evidence—in the House of Representatives, at least—that women spend their resources differently. They find evidence of women dedicating more of their budget toward franking, but they do not find evidence that women spend more money on traveling to their district, nor do they spend more money on hiring additional staffers in their district.

Goodman and Parker (2010) adopt a "Fenno-esque" framework and utilize the proportion of MRA each member spends on travel, franking, and office expenses to determine what factors might predict which type of home style a member adopts. They find evidence that members pursue multiple goals: while some might seek to increase name recognition by allocating more funds to franking, others might seek to pursue legislative goals and gain influence through the House of Representatives by spending more on office expenses—including personnel.

Bernhard and Sulkin (2018) are similarly interested in classifying a latent "style" of legislator, and consider members' budgetary allocations as one of several relevant domains of members' behavior. Yet rather than observing the full set of expenses a member makes, they limit their analysis of budgetary expenses to the realm of "district attention," as observed by the number of district offices a member opens and the proportion of her staff that works in her district.

Lastly, Crosson et al. (2021) use MRA expenditures as their dependent variable to evaluate a decline in congressional capacity, but limit the scope of their analysis to the prediction of the proportion of MRA spent on personnel, rather than considering broader trends in spending across a variety of accounts.

While each of these studies represents a critical effort to better understand the choices members make with the budgetary discretion afforded to them, I intend to extend this literature with a slightly different theoretical focus and a number of additional empirical analyses, pertaining specifically to the added variation members experienced due to recent changes in the congressional funding structure. I outline both the changes to the budgetary structure and my theoretical expectations in the following sections.

3 | CHANGES TO BUDGETARY ACCOUNTS

The 117th Congress was not a traditional Congress in the world of congressional budgets. During the 117th Congress, members in the House of Representatives experienced three structural changes to their budgetary operations. The first was an increase in the staff-salary ceiling, imposed by Speaker Nancy Pelosi (D-Calif.). The second change was an overall increase in members' representational allowances, implemented by the Fiscal Year 2022 Appropriations Act. Lastly, Speaker Pelosi implemented, for the first time, a floor on congressional-staff salaries.

Due to the nature of the ceiling and floor adjustments coming from the Speaker's office and requiring no legislative implementation, the process by which each policy was proposed and announced is relatively opaque. The MRA increase, on the other hand, was the result of a months-long negotiation with ample supporting text explaining the rationale and intended implementation of the increase in funds. Furthermore, the imposition of a salary floor is a mandatory policy with which members must abide. The increase in MRA funds and the raise in the ceiling, however, are entirely discretionary in nature. Members do not have to spend the additional funds, nor do they have to raise salaries that were at the previous ceiling.

These three events occurred over the course of just over a year, yet all within the same Congress. The consistency of the set of members coupled with the variation in resources, restrictions, and implementations of each new policy allow me to test the effects of these changes to the funding structure. In this section, I first outline each event that occurred, and then detail the model I employ to test the effect of increased spending on congressional staff.

3.1 | Leadership-directed adjustments

Recognizing the "important contribution that Congressional staff makes to fulfilling our legislative and constituent responsibilities," on August 12, 2021, Speaker Nancy Pelosi announced an increase in the

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staff-salary ceiling, bumping it up from $173,900 to $199,300[7] and then up again to $203,700 on May 6, 2022 to match the increase in the Senate staff ceiling.[8] As noted by Speaker Pelosi, the announcement to increase the staff-salary ceiling came at the recommendation of the chair of the House Committee on Administration, Zoe Lofgren, as well as the House Select Committee on Modernization. Pelosi was explicit in noting that an increase in the salary ceiling should make Congress more competitive with other federal-government employees, which would hopefully improve staff retention. Increasing retention was also the logic behind implementing a floor on staff salaries.[9]

In her May 6, 2022 Dear Colleague Letter, Speaker Pelosi announced that effective September 1, 2022, the House minimum annual pay for staff would be set at $45,000. As mentioned above, this move to implement a salary floor was partially motivated by the need to increase retention, but also out of fairness, as Pelosi noted that "many of the youngest staffers working the longest hours often earn the lowest salaries."[10] This imposition of a salary floor affected the vast majority of offices on Capitol Hill. In the 116th Congress, just one Congress prior to Speaker Pelosi setting a minimum salary of $45,000, over 97% of all offices in the House of Representatives had at least one full-time employee who did not meet this salary floor.

3.2 | Budgetary increase

The notion that congressional staff are underpaid and overworked is not new (Fox & Hammond, 1977; Salisbury & Shepsle, 1981a, 1981b), nor is it met with much dispute. This under-compensation has led to the well-documented "brain drain" of seasoned Capitol Hill veterans leaving public service to pursue more financially fruitful careers on K Street.[11] Approximately 25% of congressional staff expect to leave their jobs within 3 years (Furnas et al., 2020) and 65% of congressional staff report that they plan to leave the Hill within 5 years (Furnas & LaPira, 2020). Perspectives on how best to address this personnel deficiency are plentiful and wide-ranging (e.g., Furnas & LaPira, 2020; LaPira et al., 2020; Reynolds, 2021). Knowing, however, that congressional staff actively influence members' ability to represent their constituents, it is not unreasonable to suggest that an investment in staff will increase members' quality of representation (Grose et al., 2007; Montgomery & Nyhan, 2017; Rosenthal & Bell, 2003). If congressional-staff salaries must increase in order to improve the quality of representation and congressional capacity, as most scholars agree (Madonna & Ostrander, 2020; McCrain, 2018), then the account from which members pay their employees must increase in such a way that prioritizes staff.

With President Biden's signature on the legislative branch appropriations bill for fiscal year 2022, Congress increased the amount of funding it appropriates to itself for the functioning of the House. This law included a widely praised 21% increase in the line-item allocation for members' representational allowances and increased the account for MRAs to the highest funding level they had ever reached (Brudnick, 2020).[12] The passage of this increased funding was perceived by close watchers of Congress as a positive indication of members' general support for improving congressional capacity through a specific investment in congressional salaries.

While many hailed this increase in the line-item amount for members' budgets as a win for underpaid staff, there was reason to doubt whether this proposed increase would translate into the paychecks of congressional staff or what the consequences for members' productivity would be. The Appropriations Committee's accompanying report to the Legislative Branch Appropriations Act mentions explicitly that the increase in MRA funding was intended to be directed to staff salaries, yet the legislation does not mandate that members comply with such a suggestion.[13] Members were, therefore, still given the discretion to divide their MRA as they please. Unlike the salary floor and ceiling with which members are required to comply, there is no statutory mandate in this law requiring members to spend this additional 21% on salary increases for their employees. A member could choose to take more trips back home to her district, update her office's technology, or, as many fiscally conservative members do, she could choose not to spend the entirety of her MRA.[14] How members chose to divide their newly expanded budget, therefore, sheds much light on their priorities and legislative style. With expenditure reports from before and after this MRA increase, I am able to isolate the exact manner in which members went about spending—or not spending—these previously unaccounted for funds, and evaluate the effect of this spending on their legislative productivity.

4 | EFFECT OF SPENDING ON LEGISLATIVE OUTCOMES

As illustrated above, scholars have long sought to understand the strategic choices members make with the limited amount of discretion they are afforded. The choices members make in determining both how much of their budget to spend and where to allocate these funds have significant consequences for legislative productivity.

I argue, first, that members who spend a greater share of their budget will be more effective lawmakers than those who "return money to the Treasury," or simply do not utilize all the resources available to them.

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An increase in funds will have no effect on capacity if the additional funds go unspent. Members, therefore, must spend their resources to see any sort of return. Even while controlling for partisanship—as the vast majority of claims touting the return of unspent funds to the Treasury are made by Republican members of Congress—members on both sides of the aisle who forego resources will be less equipped to succeed.

> Rate of spending Hypothesis (H1): Members of Congress who spend a greater percentage of their MRA will be more effective lawmakers.

As articulated by Fong et al. (2025), even while Congress might make good-faith efforts to boost capacity by increasing the resources made available to members—such as the one experienced in Fiscal Year 2022—individual legislators often remain reluctant to spend taxpayer dollars on internal expenses. Members who see the value in spending the resources allocated to them would—whether implicitly or explicitly—acknowledge the necessity of these institutional investments to boost congressional capacity.

Lee (2016) notes, however, that members "increasingly devote personal staff resources to media and district-specific positions suggest[ing] that not all reforms will increase policy capacity" (Madonna & Ostrander, 2020, p. 275). Like Lee, I suggest that members wishing to boost their policy capacity should invest additional resources in their *legislative* staff. Salisbury and Shepsle (1981a) aruge that "the core of any congressional enterprise is the personal staff of the member" (561), but I contend that a member's legislative staff is the core of a member's legislative operation. While adding funds to one's constituent services staff might improve the quality of a member's constituent-oriented casework or allow for higher levels of attentiveness in densely populated areas with high rates of campaign donations (Kaslovsky, 2022), there is no reason to believe investing in district-focused staff will have an effect on a member's legislative performance. I argue that spending additional funds on legislative staff, in particular, will have the greatest payoff in terms of legislative effectiveness.

> Legislative spending Hypothesis (H2): Members of Congress who spend more of their MRA on legislative staff, in particular, will be more effective lawmakers.

As will be explained below, the leading measure by which scholars evaluate members' legislative effectiveness is Volden and Wiseman's (2014) legislative effectiveness scores (LES). These scores "capture the relative share of all legislative activities in any 2-year Congress that can be attributed to each lawmaker" (Volden & Wiseman, 2014, p. 25). To calculate a member's LES, Volden and Wiseman use 15 indicators to create a measure of how far a member's sponsored bills advance in the legislative process, weighted by the relative importance of each bill.

An increased investment in legislative staff should boost member's legislative effectiveness scores in a number of ways. First and foremost, out of all types of congressional staff, legislative staff are the ones most directly responsible for moving their boss' legislative priorities through the legislative process. Legislative staff are the ones who research policy, draft bill text, refine provisions with legislative counsels, coordinate with potential co-sponsors, work with committee staff, and negotiate with leadership, the Senate, and the White House. As legislative effectiveness scores are calculated by tracking how far members' bills make it through these steps, an investment in legislative staff should have the highest payoff for a member's legislative effectiveness, as opposed to an investment in constituent services staff, for example, who do not play as direct of a role in this process.

Second, investing in legislative staff will allow members to retain better staff. As mentioned in previous sections, Capitol Hill is engaged in a fierce labor competition with the private sector. If members are able to raise the salaries of their staff, they are more likely to be able to retain their top talent, rather than losing expertise to the private sector. These experienced legislative staffers are the most equipped to navigate the legislative process and have the deepest networks to make the process as smooth as possible, helping their boss advance their legislative priorities.

Lastly, depending on how many staff a member previously employed, an increased investment might allow a member to hire additional staff. As legislative effectiveness is a function not only of how *far* a member's introduced legislation makes it through the process, but also how *much* of a member's legislation they are able to move, additional legislative staffers allow members the opportunity to work simultaneously on multiple priorities.

5 | DATA AND MODELS

The Chief Administrative Officer (CAO) of the House of Representatives published data on the MRA assigned to each member in each year, as well as records of each expenditure made by each member in quarterly reports since 2009. I use the full history of data, as well as a subset of these reports immediately before and after the shocks in the 117th Congress. As stated in previous sections, members' individual budgets are determined by a number of district-specific factors, including the anticipated cost of renting office space and the number of mailing addresses in their district. For this reason, it is

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more helpful to evaluate the percentage of a member's budget she spent, rather than the raw dollar amount spent. Evaluating members' total spending would make it seem as if members in regions with lower costs of living are more frugal, as they spend a lower dollar amount than members in higher cost of living regions. The CAO, however, expects these members in lower cost of living regions to require fewer resources than their colleagues in regions with higher costs of living. Observing members' rate of spending relative to their own MRA cap, however, allows for a more nuanced evaluation of factors that affect spending habits, other than regional expenses.

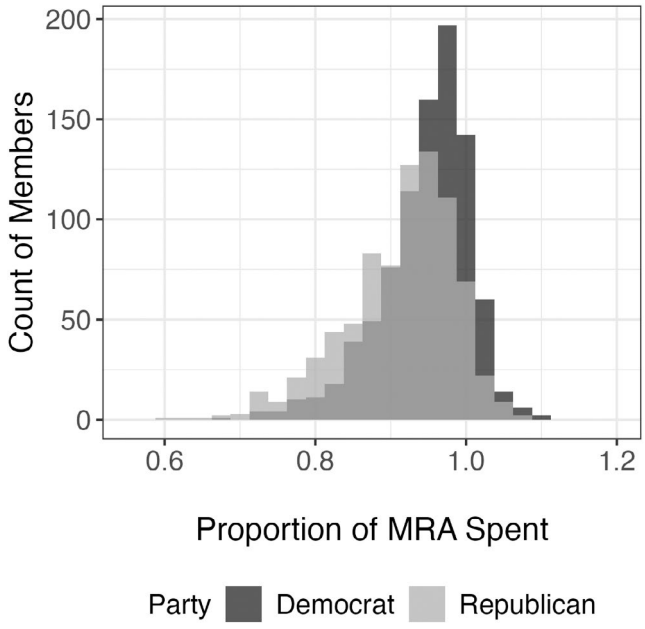


FIGURE 1 Proportion of MRA spent (2019–2022).

In both the 116th and 117th Congresses, it is clear that members are aware of their budgetary cap. As is evident in Figure 1, the vast majority of members spend between 90% and 100% of their budget in a given year. The mean percentage spent across 2019 and 2022 is 93.1%, with a minimum value of 60.7%, spent by Rep. James Baird (R-IN) and a maximum value of 111%, spent by Rep. Elizabeth Fletcher (D-TX). Despite the handful of Republican members who express interest in "returning money to the Treasury [Department]," the average Democrat only spends about 3% more of her budget than the average Republican. It is worth noting that over 10% of members do spend more than their congressionally allocated budget each year. Interviews with congressional staff who have worked in offices that have overspent their budgets indicate that members who have higher personal net worths tend to feel less constrained by their MRA, as the punishment for overspending one's account is simply to pay it back with a member's own personal funds. These members who spent more than their allocated MRA did tend to invest it in staff—primarily in legislative, communications, and constituent services staff.[15]

Figure 2 depicts the fact that compared to previous years, fewer members in both 2021 and 2022 spent over 90% of their budget. In fact, the differences in means between each consecutive Congress is significant across each of these three time periods. The vertical lines in Figure 2 mark the average percentage of a member's budget that was spent in each year. This average percent of her budget a member spends increases from 2019 to 2020 by 2.12% (p-value < 0.001), but in each of the next 2 years, the mean amount of spending decreases significantly. Between 2020 and 2021, the mean percentage of a member's budget they spend decreases by 3.96% (p-value < 0.001), and between 2021 and 2022, the mean percentage spent decreases by 1.82% (p-value < 0.001).

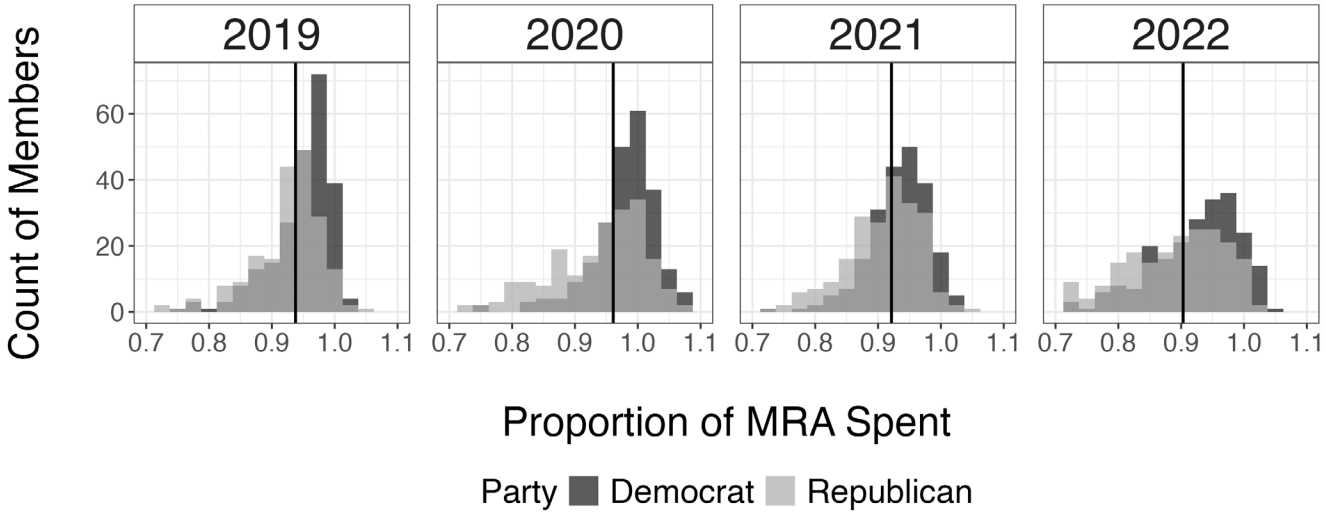


FIGURE 2 Proportion of MRA spent (2019–2022).

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While considering the rate of members' spending is helpful for identifying trends across a variety of districts, observing the percent change in MRA spent across a period in which the MRA cap was increased, however, masks the fact that the average *amount* of spending did, in fact, increase in 2022 when members were able to spend more money. Figure 3 illustrates that the amount of money members spent from their MRA does increase across each of these 4 years, with statistically significant increases from 2019 to 2020 (p-value < 0.001) and from 2021 to 2022 (p-value < 0.001).

As noted above, when assessing the percentage change from 2021 to 2022, members' rates of spending goes down (Figure 2), but this masks the fact that the raw dollar amount spent increases (Figure 3). While I still contend that rate of spending is the appropriate measure by which to evaluate members' behavior, due to these structural changes that occurred in 2022 it is more useful when evaluating spending rates to assess the amount of her budget a given member spent in 2022 relative to her budgetary cap in 2021, prior to the increase in funds. Holding the 2021 MRA caps constant allows for a more standardized assessment of how members went about spending—or not spending—the increase they were given.

Figure 4 highlights the fact that members did increase their rate of spending in 2022 following the changes to the funding structure, yet members did not increase their spending at a rate proportional to the 21% increase to MRAs. The vertical line depicts a mean rate of spending—relative to the 2021 cap—of 92.1% in 2021 and 109% in 2022. Yet if members were to have adjusted their spending proportionately to the funding increase, we would expect to see a mean rate of spending closer to 112% in 2022. What is clear,

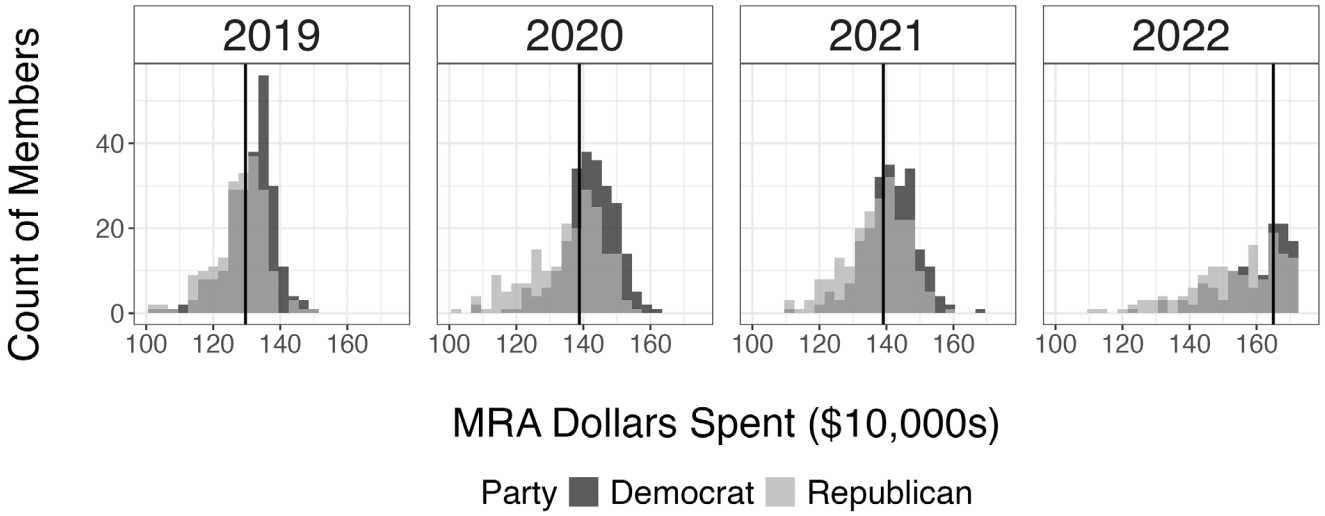


FIGURE 3 Amount of MRA spent (2019–2022).

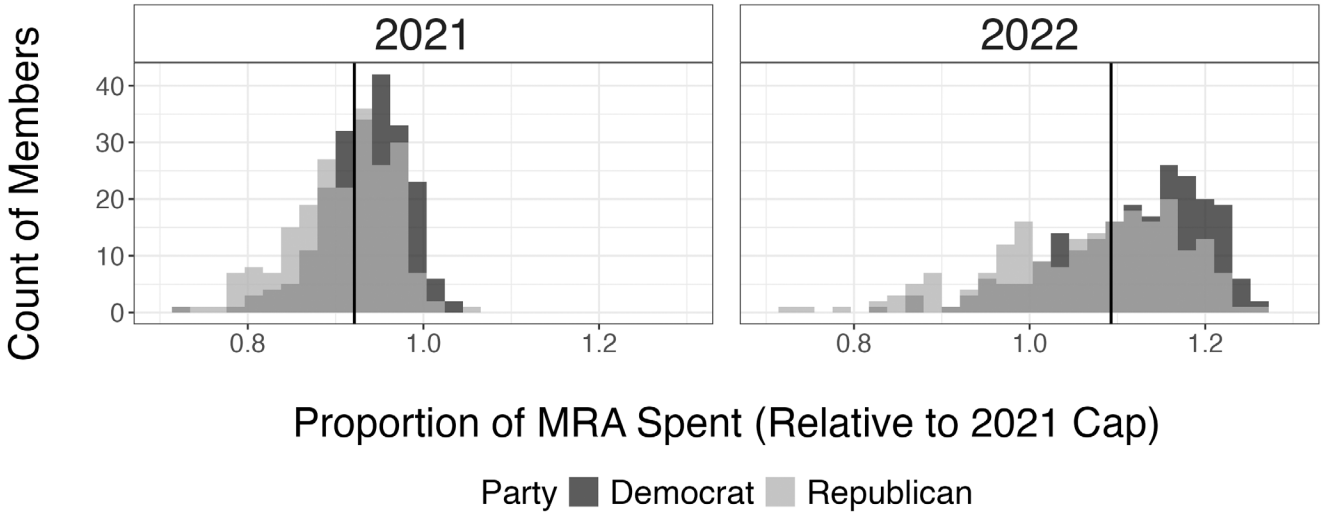


FIGURE 4 Proportion of MRA spent, relative to 2021 (2021–2022).

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no matter how one depicts the amount or percentage of spending, is that there exists substantial variation across members in how much of their overall budgets they spend. Beyond the variation that exists in how much of a member's overall budget she spends, I also demonstrate that there is variation in how much of a member's budget she devotes to personnel.

When considering the effect of overall spending on a member's legislative productivity, I use the percentage of MRA spent relative to the caps in the 116th Congress.[16] When isolating the effect of spending on particular budgetary subcategories, like personnel, for example, it is more illustrative to use the raw dollar amount.

As mentioned previously, each MRA is calculated as a function of a base personnel stipend, the distance from the member's district to Washington, the General Services Administration rate for office space in her district, and the amount of non-business mailing addresses in the member's district. What is held constant across all members—regardless of any district-varying factors—is the suggested amount she should spend on personnel compensation. In other words, while a member from New York City would have a larger MRA than a member representing Wyoming, this discrepancy is due to the fact that office space is more expensive in New York City than Wyoming, as well as the fact that there are more residential mailing addresses in the New York member's district than Wyoming. Despite these differences, each member would have an equal allocation added to their MRA—independent of any district characteristics—intended to be spent on personnel. A member can, however, choose to divide her MRA across these categories with complete discretion. As the CAO lists a specific amount designated in each member's MRA to be spent on personnel—despite the fact that they are not obligated to spend these funds in this way—and all members face the same limit on the number of staff they can hire (18), I argue that considering the *amount* of money spent on this budgetary category is more informative than analyzing the *percentage* of a member's budget spent on staff. While the rate of a member's spending is the appropriate unit of analysis for any inquiries regarding patterns of overall spending, or any questions related to district-variant factors (e.g., franking), the dollar amount a member spends on staff is more informative, as it is held constant across all members in the CAO's MRA formula.

Figure 5 illustrates that between 2019 and 2022, members have increased the amount of money they have spent on personnel. The mean amount spent on personnel (denoted by the vertical line) in 2021 was $1,073,450, while the mean in 2022 was $1,277,962 ($p$-value < 0.001). This increase, however, has not been uniform: the difference across parties in each year is statistically significant. In each of these 4 years, Democrats always outspend Republicans, ranging from a difference of 2.9% in 2019 (p-value < 0.01) to a difference of 11.8% in 2022 (p-value < 0.001).

Before exploring how spending is associated with legislative productivity, it is worth uncovering the factors that relate to higher—or lower—levels of spending both in general and on personnel, in particular. Figure 6 presents two models indicating what member-level factors are predictive of higher rates of spending (left panel) and what factors are predictive of greater amounts of money being spent on personnel (right panel).[17] Consistent with results presented above, when evaluating spending habits in general, I compare members using the percentage of a member's budget, as compared to evaluating the dollar amount spent on staff.

Consistent with public perception of how members spend their budgets and the data presented in Figure 5, Republicans are more likely to leave MRA resources unspent than Democrats, and they are less

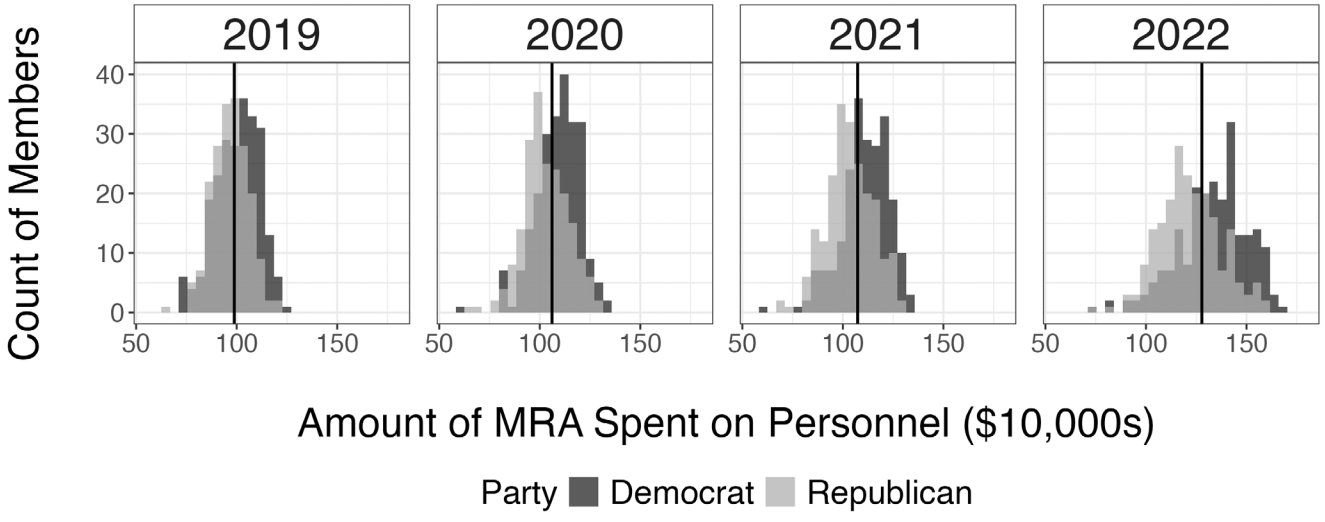


FIGURE 5 Amount of MRA spent on personnel (2019–2022).

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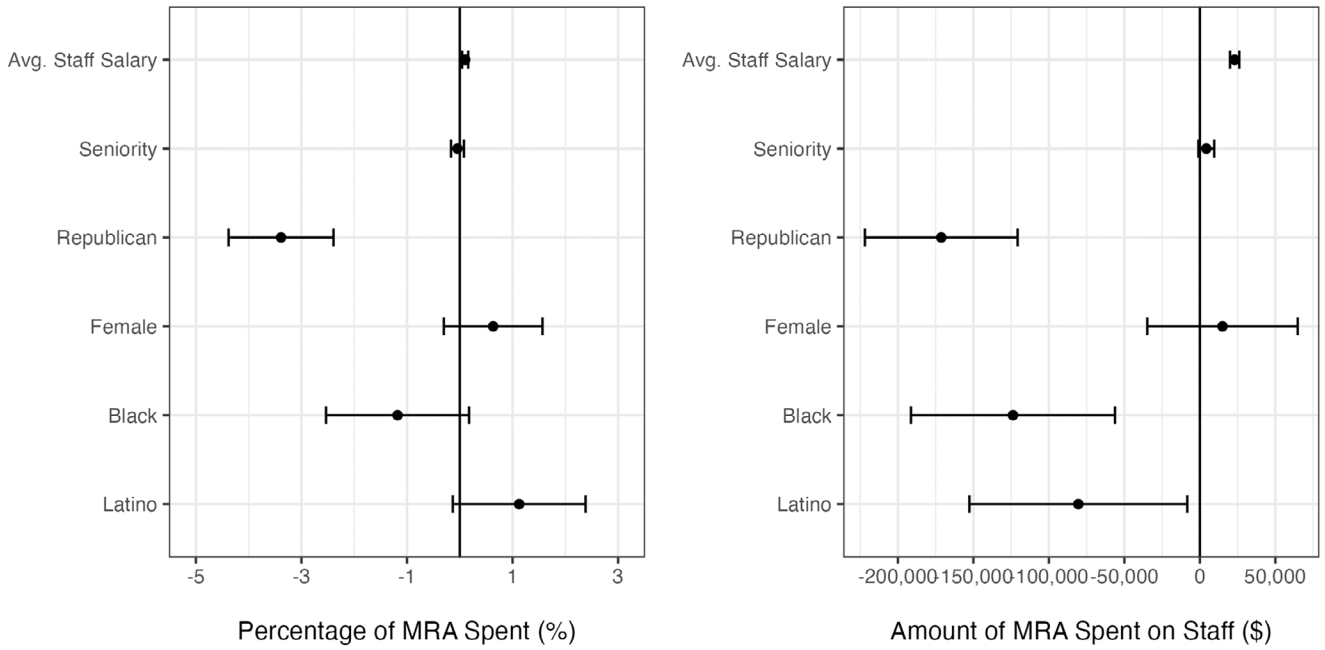


FIGURE 6 Factors affecting spending (2019–2022).

likely to invest in their staff. Republicans, in fact, spend nearly $140,000 less on their staff over the course of a Congress than Democrats. Additionally, Black and Latino members of Congress are less likely to invest in staff.

Figure 6 also illustrates that the average salary of a member's staff in a given Congress is positively predictive of both how much of her MRA a member will spend and how much of it she will spend on her staff. This significant relationship demonstrates that members who invest more of their resources in staff are not simply hiring more staff, but rather they are paying their existing staff more. In fact, the median member across these two Congresses employs 17.11 staffers. While some staff turnover is to be expected, a median value just one staffer below the maximum of 18 staff per office suggests that the vast majority of members do not have the ability to hire more staff. If a member's increased investment in personnel took the form of hiring new staff, rather than paying existing staff more, there would be no relationship between staff salaries and an investment in personnel. But as Figure 6 depicts, there is a positive and statistically significant relationship between how much a member pays each staffer and her overall investment in staff. It appears, therefore, that as members invest more resources in their staff, they are investing them in improving the salaries of existing staff, rather than hiring more staff.

Further, knowing that offices were required to comply with a salary floor imposed in the 117th Congress, it should not be surprising that the coefficient for the average salary of a member's staff is positive. We should expect to see the average salary increase across this time period, and that it would be positively associated with members spending more of their resources on staff.[18] The magnitude of this increase in salary, however, outpaces the increase mandated by the salary floor.

In the 116th Congress, the mean salary for the lowest-paid staffer in each office was approximately $34,000. In the 117th Congress, the mean salary of the staffer with the lowest salary in each office was just over $42,000.[19] Though the imposition of a salary floor did constrain members' spending to a certain degree, the average office needed to allocate just over $16,000 to be in compliance with the new policy. Due to the proportional increase in all MRAs in the 117th Congress, the average member had roughly $500,000 more to spend in the 117th Congress than the 116th Congress, leaving the allocation of a significant amount of funds up to each member's discretion. In fact, the average member invested nearly half of these new funds in their staff in the 117th Congress. It is clear, therefore, that as members choose to pay their existing staff more, and they are doing so not only because they are obligated to meet a new floor, but because they see the benefit in improving their staff's salaries.

Beyond observing varying patterns in how members choose to spend their resources, analyzing the consequences of such choices will uncover key insights as to how members ought to spend their resources if they desire legislative productivity.

The outcome variable I am interested in assessing—using spending in MRA accounts as my key independent variables—is legislative effectiveness. The leading account by which congressional scholars evaluate a given member's legislative process is Volden and Wiseman's (2014) legislative effectiveness scores,

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or LES. Using the member-level variable of legislative effectiveness scores as my dependent variable, I determine the effect of members' personal budgetary decisions on their productivity and capabilities as a legislator.

As established in the hypotheses above, I expect that members who spend a higher percentage of their budget will be associated with higher levels of lawmaking productivity, and those who allocate more resources to their legislative staff, in particular, will be more legislatively effective. These scores are calculated at the Congress level, requiring me to collapse my expenditures data from quarterly reports to Congress-level summaries.

As mentioned previously, the nature of the funding changes in the 117th Congress added additional variation in spending patterns. Employing fixed effects by Congress and random effects by member allow me to assess the precise nature in which spending across MRA categories is associated with legislative productivity. To test Hypothesis 1, I evaluate what effect the percentage of her MRA a member spends has on her legislative effectiveness.

In addition to the independent variable of interest (percentage of MRA spent), I include the same battery of independent variables that Volden and Wiseman (2014) incorporate in their analysis of legislative effectiveness. The equation to estimate the effect of this treatment on a given member's legislative effectiveness, therefore, will take the form:

$$LES_{it} = \beta_1 \text{Percentage of MRA Spent}_{it} + \beta_{2-9} \text{LES IVs}_{it} + \gamma_t + \delta_i + \epsilon_{it} \quad (1)$$

where β_1 is the percentage of MRA a member spent, relative to her cap in the 116th Congress. β_{2-9} represents all the time-variant personal and institutional factors that Volden and Wiseman incorporate in their effectiveness models.[20] γ_t represents Congress fixed effects, δ_i represents the member-level random effects, and ϵ_{it} are the standard errors, clustered at the member level.[21]

In a second model, I return to the full set of data (2009–2022) made available by the House Clerk's office to evaluate Hypothesis 2 and determine, more specifically, how an investment in staff is associated with legislative productivity. In this model, rather than including the percentage of MRA a member spends as my key independent variable, I include the amount she spent across each staffing category:

$$\text{LES}_{it} = \beta_{1-5} \text{Amount of MRA Spent}_{it} + \beta_{6-14} \text{LES IVs}_{it} + \gamma_t + \delta_i + \epsilon_{it} \quad (2)$$

β_{1-5}, here, is the investment across five staff categories, as developed by Crosson et al. (2021). To determine these staff categories, I follow a similar coding scheme as Crosson et al. (2021), which results in the five staff categories of legislative, constituent services, communications, political management, and office management.[22] As staff fill a variety of roles within a congressional office, it is rational to expect their effect on legislative productivity to differ. With these specific categories I am able to identify which, if any, staff are the most pivotal in boosting a member's legislative effectiveness.

In this model, I, again, isolate the effect of spending on an individual's legislative effectiveness using member-level random effects and Congress level fixed effects (γ_t and δ_i). Consistent with the model above, the inclusion of member-level random effects allows me to remove the time-invariant controls, leaving only the time-varying controls of a member's seniority, whether she is in the majority party, whether she is a member of majority or minority leadership, whether she is the speaker, whether she holds a committee or subcommittee chair, if she serves on any power committees, and the margin of her most recent election as those variables represented by β_{6-14}.

6 | RESULTS

Table 1 depicts the first model described above, predicting the effect the percentage MRA spent has on a member's legislative effectiveness score while controlling for the typical battery of time-varying factors that are correlated with lawmaking effectiveness.

When controlling for the usual factors that are associated with a member's legislative effectiveness score, such as her seniority and whether she holds a committee chair, a member spending a greater percentage of her budget (relative to her 116th limit) is significantly predictive of an increase in legislative effectiveness at the $p < 0.1$ level.[23] Consistent with Hypothesis 1, this suggests that if a member is motivated to boost her legislative productivity, she should forgo the desire to "return funds to the Treasury," and rather spend the funds appropriated to her. Holding all else equal, if a member were to spend just 5% more of her funds, or about $90,000, she could increase her effectiveness by roughly 0.05 points, which is greater than the difference between two of a member's introduced commemorative bills passing the House becoming law.[24] But surely a member spending an additional $90,000 on office supplies, for example, would not have the same effect on her legislative productivity as it would if she invested it in her staff. So how, exactly might a member choose to spend these funds to boost her productivity? This is what I uncover in the following model.

To assess the precise effect of an investment in staff on legislative productivity, I include five specific staff categories, as outlined in Equation (2). Figure 7 illustrates the effect increasing the amount of money (in units of $100,000) a member spends on each MRA

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TABLE 1 Legislative effectiveness and the rate of MRA spending.

	Dependent variable
	Legislative Effectiveness Score
Proportion MRA spent	0.956*
	(0.530)
Seniority	0.026**
	(0.011)
Majority	0.562***
	(0.093)
Maj. leadership	0.530
	(0.417)
Min. leadership	0.091
	(0.163)
Speaker	−1.760***
	(0.472)
Chair	1.899***
	(0.485)
Subcommittee chair	0.241*
	(0.136)
Power committee	−0.259**
	(0.103)
Electoral margin	−0.006*
	(0.003)
Congress FE	✓
Member RE	✓
Member standard deviation	0.380
Observations	846
Log likelihood	−1109.565
Akaike Inf. Crit.	2247.130
Bayesian Inf. Crit.	2313.497

Note: Multilevel linear model with clustered standard errors by member in parentheses. Includes data from the 116th and 117th Congresses. Percent of MRA spent is relative to each member's cap in the 116th Congress.
*$p<0.1$; **$p<0.05$; ***$p<0.01$.

account has on her legislative effectiveness score.[25] Consistent with Hypothesis 2, I find evidence to suggest that an investment in legislative staff has the greatest returns for improving legislative effectiveness.[26] These findings are consistent when considering the components that contribute to legislative effectiveness, as well.[27] Appendix D Table 2 demonstrates that legislative staff have a positive and significant effect on a member's legislative productivity at each stage of the legislative process.

In addition to an investment in legislative staff having a positive and significant effect on legislative effectiveness, investing in political management staff also effects a member's legislative productivity. Though

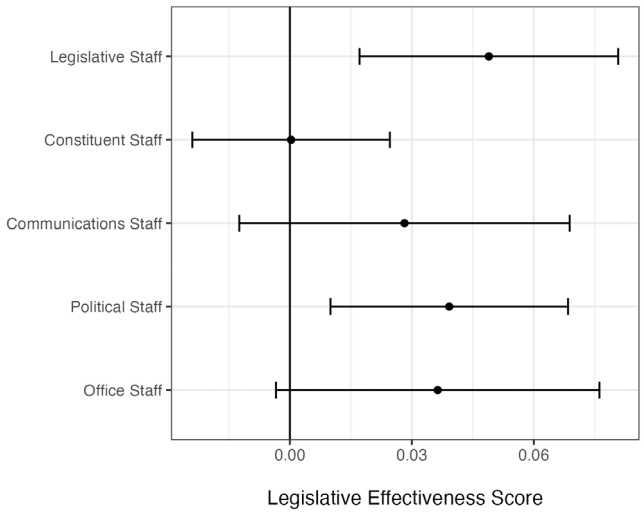


FIGURE 7 Amount of MRA spent on staff (2009–2022). Staff categories are displayed in $100,000s.

not as large of an effect size as legislative staff, it is clear that if a member were to invest in an experienced chief of staff or senior counsel, for example, she would see the investment pay off in terms of her legislative performance. Unlike the other three staff categories (constituent services, communications, and office management staff), political management staff are the next most likely, behind legislative staff, to be involved in assisting a member of Congress navigate the legislative process. Members' counsels likely liaise with the Office of Legislative Counsel, and chiefs of staff likely partake in high-level negotiations, which theoretically motivates the statistically significant, positive relationship between an investment in political management staff and legislative effectiveness. As seen in Appendix D Table 2, political staff are positively and significantly associated with productivity at each stage of the legislative process.[28]

Having found support for both of my hypotheses outlined above, I conclude by determining the precise effect that an increase in staff spending had on a member's lawmaking productivity in the 117th Congress. With the 2022 fiscal year appropriation increasing members' budgetary accounts by 21%, members received budgets that were, on average, $300,000 larger in 2022 than they were in 2021. In this final model, illustrated in Figure 8 below (full model results can be found in Appendix B Table 3), I demonstrate that members who invested these additional funds in legislative staff, in particular, saw the benefits of this investment in the form of an increased legislative effectiveness rank.[29]

While Figure 7 illustrates that an investment in legislative and political staff is associated with higher legislative effectiveness scores across the 111th to 117th Congresses, Figure 8 demonstrates that members who invested the additional funds they received in the 117th

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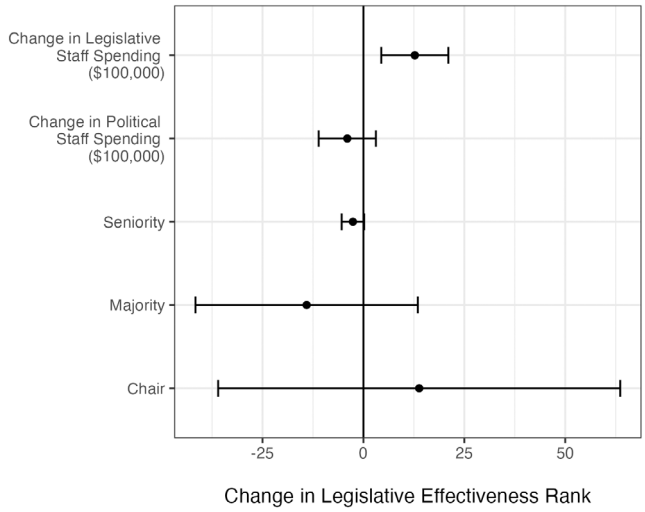


FIGURE 8 Change in amount of MRA spent on staff (116th to 117th congress).

in legislative staff, in particular, saw the greatest return on investment in the form of lawmaking productivity. All else equal, members who invested one third of their extra funds, or $100,000, in their legislative staff could expect to see their legislative effectiveness rank move up nearly 13 spots from the 116th Congress to the 117th Congress. If a member were to invest all $300,000 of her additional funds in her legislative team, her boost in legislative effectiveness would, on average, be equivalent to the difference between two of her commemorative bills passing the House and becoming law, the difference between one of her substantive bills receiving action beyond the committee stage and passing the House, or the difference between one of her substantive and significant bills receiving action in committee and receiving action on the floor of the House.[30]

Rep. Earl Blumenauer (D-Ore.), for example, invested nearly all of his MRA increase in the 117th Congress in his legislative staff. Rep. Blumenauer's budget increased from $2,938,668 in the 116th Congress to $3,459,664 in the 117th Congress. Of the $328,746 increase he received in 2022 due to the 21% increase in the 2022 appropriation, he invested just over $300,000 of it in his legislative staff. This choice paid off for Rep. Blumenauer, as his legislative effectiveness score saw an increase of 1.13 points in the 117th Congress compared to the 116th Congress. This increase in productivity due in large part to introducing five more bills than he did in the previous Congress, and having two of those substantive and significant bills be signed into law. Rep. Blumenauer held a subcommittee chair in both the 116th and 117th Congresses, served on the same committees, and won each of his elections by identical margins. The greatest change contributing to the difference in his legislative effectiveness between the 116th and 117th Congresses, therefore, is how he allocated his funds. As expected, an increased investment in his legislative staff paid off in terms of his legislative productivity in the 117th Congress, and Rep. Blumenauer went from meeting expectations as the 89th most-effective Democrat in the 116th Congress to exceeding expectations as the 24th most-effective Democrat in the 117th Congress.[31]

Rep. Norma Torres (D-Calif.), on the other hand, failed to spend much of her MRA increase at all. She spent less than 10% of the additional funds she received in the 117th Congress and, in fact, spent less on her legislative staff in the 117th Congress than she did in the 116th Congress. As is consistent with my hypotheses, spending both a lower percentage of her MRA and less on her legislative staff had negative effects on her legislative productivity. Her legislative effectiveness score decreased by half a point, moving her from meeting expectations for legislative effectiveness as the 167th most-effective Democrat in the 116th Congress to below expectations as the 52nd least-effective Democrat in the 117th. In the 116th Congress, she had three bills receive action in committee, two pass the House, and one become law. In the 117th Congress, however, none of her sponsored bills received action in committee or beyond.

Even for members who did spend their additional funds in the 117th Congress, failing to invest these resources in legislative staff had little payoff in terms of legislative productivity. Rep. Janice Schakowsky (D-Ill.), for example, did spend an additional $329,080 in the 117th Congress, but only increased her legislative staff spending by $3,038. Rep. Schakowsky spent more of her MRA on her office management staff team and on traveling back to her district, but as Figures 7 and 8 indicate, investing in these MRA accounts has no statistically significant effect on legislative effectiveness. As such, Rep. Schakowsky's, legislative effectiveness decreased slightly from the 116th Congress to the 117th Congress, but she continued to meet expectations for legislative effectiveness in both Congresses.

7 | CONCLUSION

Recognizing that members of Congress enter their careers with a multitude of legislative goals, I seek to understand how they go about accomplishing them. Because members of Congress are constrained by numerous institutional barriers, in considering how they allocate the resources over which they have near total discretion, we can learn a great deal about both what motivates members of Congress and what makes some members of Congress more successful at achieving these goals than others. Members have a variety of representational goals, but in this paper, I uncover how members go about equipping themselves to achieve their legislative goals. Future work should consider how

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members allocate their resources to achieve a variety of other representational and electoral goals.

It is clear that there are meaningful differences across time and across budgetary categories in how members go about spending their resources, and I demonstrate that members who choose to spend a greater percentage of their budget tend to see higher levels of legislative productivity. Further, using a change to the funding structure coupled with member-level random effects and Congress fixed effects, I show that an increased investment in legislative staff has a statistically significant effect on boosting a member's legislative effectiveness.

These findings diverge from Crosson et al. (2020), in which they find no significant effect of members' spending on their lawmaking productivity. I suggest that the significant effect I uncover here might be a result of one key difference in the data. Crosson et al. (2020) rely on data of members' spending habits from 1994 through 2013, whereas the data upon which I rely incorporate the crucial years around which members accessed additional flexibility as a result of changes in the MRA funding structure. By incorporating these years, I gain additional variance in members' spending patterns, and am able to observe the effect of spending on lawmaking effectiveness more closely. These findings underscore the fact that as members gain additional flexibility to make decisions in accordance with their preferences, a member who cares about being a productive lawmaker ought to invest her resources in staff committed to this effort.

Volden and Wiseman (2014) suggest that three components are necessary for members to become effective lawmakers: "innate ability, the acquisition and cultivation of a critical skill set, and the sophisticated utilization of key legislative institutions" (30). These findings speak clearly to the second component of cultivating effectiveness. Volden and Wiseman (2014) find that members do possess innate qualities that make some more effective than others and that institutional positioning contributes to effectiveness, yet how members spend their MRA illustrates a key opportunity for members to utilize the resources afforded them to become more effective lawmakers.

This paper provides numerous opportunities for future work, including evaluating how staff respond to this increased investment in terms of turnover, and whether higher salaries do keep congressional staff from departing Capitol Hill for the private sector. Further, as more time elapses after the changes to the funding structure, future work should dive further into uncovering the differences in types of members and their spending behavior. Additionally, and perhaps quite unsurprisingly, members who do not spend their full budget invest fewer resources in communicating with their district via franked mail, and they spend fewer resources traveling back to their districts. Future work ought to uncover the extent to which constituents in districts represented by members who do not spend their full budgets receive lower-quality representation—perhaps in the form of congressionally directed spending at levels below that which was received by similar districts represented by members who do take advantage of their full budgetary allowance.

These findings add to the literature's understanding of members' budgetary choices and congressional priorities, and also take steps toward providing members of Congress with practical guidance as they establish their offices and seek to improve their legislative prowess. This project builds on key work by preeminent scholars to further establish that members make active choices about how they legislate and where they allocate resources. If members are strategic about this allocation of resources, however, they can better equip themselves to accomplish their legislative goals and improve their capacity as legislators.

DATA AVAILABILITY STATEMENT

The data that support the findings of this study are available from the corresponding author upon reasonable request.

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Endnotes

[1] Trevor Brown, Paul Moines, Lionel Ramos, and Keaton Ross, "Why Are You Running?" *Oklahoma Watch*, April 19, 2022. https://oklahomawatch.org/2022/04/19/why-are-you-running-new-returning-candidates-say-why-theyre-in-the-race%EF%BF%BC/; "Meet Marjorie," *Marjorie Greene for Congress*. https://www.mtgforamerica.com/; "Why I'm Running," *Dr. Oz: U.S. Senate*. https://doctoroz.com/why-running/.

[2] These data are reported by the U.S. House of Representatives Chief Administrative Officer, and explained in further detail below.

[3] The precise MRA appropriations change year to year, but for the purposes of a descriptive account of the average budget a member receives, the specific MRA amounts listed here and in the discussion that follows are taken from the 2024 allocations. As outlined in the following sections, when analyzing the relationship between spending and legislative outcomes, however, I consider budgets and spending patterns from 2009 to 2022.

[4] This size of the travel budget is determined via a weighted formula using data from the General Services Administration City Pair Program and the office space budget is determined by calculating the Government Services Administration rate for renting 2500 square feet of office space in a member's district.

[5] 2 U.S.C. §57.

[6] See *Members' Congressional Handbook*, United States House of Representatives Committee on House Administration, November 6, 2020.

[7] Speaker Nancy Pelosi, "Dear Colleague to All Members on the Speaker's New Pay Order", August 12, 2021. https://www.speaker.gov/newsroom/81221-0.

[8] Speaker Nancy Pelosi, "Dear Colleague to All Members on Increasing Congressional Staff Salaries," May 6, 2022. https://www.speaker.gov/newsroom/5622.

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[9] It should be noted that the Speaker of the House holds the unilateral authority to implement changes to staff salary floors and ceilings (see 2U.S.C. §4532). Any changes to members' overall budgets, however, must navigate the legislative process.

[10] Speaker Nancy Pelosi, "Dear Colleague to All Members on Increasing Congressional Staff Salaries," May 6, 2022. https://www.speaker.gov/newsroom/5622.

[11] For example, Bradford Fitch, "How Congress Can Combat Staff Brain Drain," *Congressional Management Foundation*, January 15, 2014. https://www.congressfoundation.org/news/blog/1050-how-congress-can-combat-staff-brain-drain; Valerie Soon, "How Congressional Brain Drain Undermines Equality of Opportunity," *Niskanen Center*, September 18, 2020. https://www.niskanencenter.org/how-congressional-brain-drain-undermines-equality-of-opportunity/; Chris Cioffi, "Brain drain to Biden administration comes at time of crisis for Capitol Hill," *Roll Call*, January 28, 2021. https://www.rollcall.com/2021/01/28/brain-drain-to-biden-administration-comes-at-time-of-crisis-for-capitol-hill/; Jordain Carney, "Senate GOP faces retirement brain drain," *The Hill*, March 10, 2021. https://thehill.com/homenews/senate/542421-senate-gop-faces-retirement-brain-drain.

[12] P.L. 117–103 (2022).

[13] Report to Accompany H. R. 4346, H. Rep. 117–80, 117th Congress (2021).

[14] Meredith McGehee and Jamie Neikrie, "Why the 'virtue signaling' of unspent congressional office funds hurts constituents," *Roll Call*, July 7, 2021. https://www.rollcall.com/2021/07/07/why-the-virtue-signaling-of-unspent-congressional-office-funds-hurts-constituents/.

[15] As will be explained further below, because these members invested more in legislative staff, they did see a payoff in terms of legislative effectiveness. The mean legislative effectiveness score for members who overspent their MRA is 1.18, which is above the normalized mean of 1.00 for all members.

[16] As will be explained below, due to the dependent variable's Congress-level unit of analysis, I must combine yearly expenditures to create a Congress-level independent variable, and will, therefore, compare amounts spent in both the 116th and 117th Congress to the MRA limits from the 116th Congress.

[17] Appendix B Table 1 lists the full model results.

[18] In the 116th Congress, over 97% of all offices had at least one full-time employee who received a salary below $11,250 per quarter, or $45,000 per year. The salary floor of $45,000 was put into effect on September 1, 2022, and, as a result, the vast majority of offices adjusted their personnel compensation accordingly. In the fourth quarter of 2022 (October–December), only 7.5% of offices paid a full-time employee less than $11,250. In other words, this creation of a salary floor affected nearly all offices, and nearly all offices complied. While the vast majority of offices were compelled to spend funds to comply with the new salary floor, this compulsory expense did not capture even 5% of the additional funds members received as a result of the increased MRA budgets in 2022.

[19] As the $45,000 salary floor was imposed in the third quarter of the last year of the 117th Congress, it is unsurprising that the average salary across the Congress did not yet meet this minimum.

[20] These variables include a member's seniority, whether she in the majority party, whether she is a member of majority or minority leadership, whether she is the speaker, whether she holds a committee or subcommittee chair, if she serves on any power committees, and the margin of her most recent election. As I include member-level random effects, the need to account for time-invariant factors, such as gender or race, is mitigated.

[21] As each member appears, at most, two times in this data set, it is appropriate to use random effects rather than fixed effects to avoid overfitting groups with a small number of observations (Hazlett & Wainstein, 2020).

[22] See Appendix A for a selection of the most frequently occurring titles in each category, and Crosson et al., 2021 Supplemental Information Appendix B for a detailed description of this coding process.

[23] Appendix D Table 1 demonstrates that these findings hold when the model specified in a slightly different manner. This model illustrates that members who increased their rate of spending between the 116th and 117th Congress—relative to their MRA limit in the 116th Congress—were more effective lawmakers than they were in the previous Congress, as determined by a member's change in her LES rank.

[24] Average substantive effect of legislative progression on legislative effectiveness scores for the 111th through 117th Congresses, calculated in the same manner as Volden and Wiseman (2014, p. 27), can be found in Appendix C Table 1.

[25] See Appendix B Table 2 for the full model results.

[26] One might suggest that an increase in staff spending more generally might have a similar effect on legislative effectiveness. Appendix D Table 6 presents the results of a model specified with the amount spent in the general personnel category rather than the five subcategories. This model indicates that the amount of money a member spends on her staff is predictive of how well she will outperform her legislative effectiveness at the $p < 0.01$ level. The effect size, however, is half as large as the effect size of legislative staff spending in the model with precisely defined staff categories. The difference in effect sizes suggests that pooling all staff spending together is not a helpful of assessment of determining the effect of spending on legislative productivity.

[27] See Appendix D Tables 2–5 for the results broken up by each legislative effectiveness component and significance level.

[28] Office staff are also positively and significantly associated with productivity at each stage in the process, but Appendix D Table 5 indicates that this is likely due to their role in assisting their bosses introduce messaging, commemorative legislation. Political and legislative staff are more closely connected with the legislation deemed substantive or substantive and significant.

[29] As legislative effectiveness scores capture a member's lawmaking productivity within a given Congress, a conventional method to observe a member's change in productivity over time is to observe the difference in her effectiveness ranking relative to her peers in each Congress.

[30] See Appendix C Table 1 for the average effect of legislative progression on legislative effectiveness.

[31] Volden and Wiseman (2014) determine whether a member falls below, meets, or exceeds her expected level of lawmaking effectiveness by comparing her Legislative Effectiveness Score (LES) to a benchmark value. This benchmark is determined by regressing LES onto indicators for committee chair, subcommittee chair, majority-party status, and seniority. A member who earns a score that is at least 1.5 greater than her benchmark is deemed to have exceeded her expected value of lawmaking effectiveness. A member whose LES to benchmark ratio is less than 0.5 has not met expectations for lawmaking effectiveness. All lawmakers whose score falls between 0.5 and 1.5 of their benchmark value, therefore, has met expectations for effectiveness.

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SUPPORTING INFORMATION

Additional supporting information can be found online in the Supporting Information section at the end of this article.

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